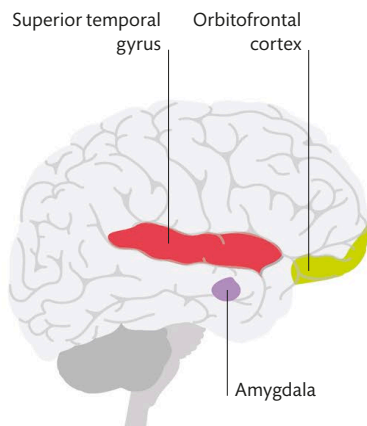


Body Language

Body language is nonverbal communication, in which our thoughts, intentions, or feelings are expressed by physical behaviors such as body posture, gestures, eye movements, and facial expressions.

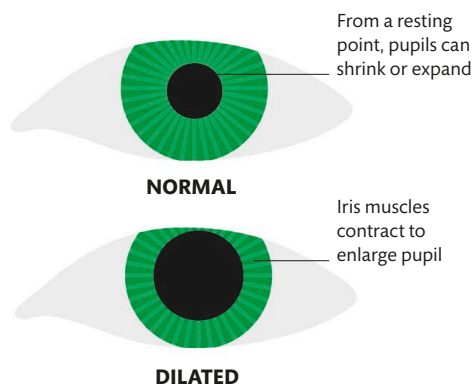
Nonconscious communication

Social interactions between people involve complex streams of nonverbal communication that are processed in parallel to speech. Many aspects of body language arise instinctively—eye movements, facial expressions, and posture, for example, all change without conscious control. These movements can therefore reveal unspoken intentions. Body language is also used to signal social intentions overtly, such as when blowing a kiss. The richness of this communication involves the whole body and our brains are attuned to it.



Brain processes

Processing body language involves areas like the amygdala, which receives emotional content; part of the superior temporal gyrus, which responds to seeing human movement; and the orbitofrontal cortex, which analyzes meaning. Special cells, called mirror neurons (see pp.102–103), are also activated when you see someone else moving.



Eye signals

Pupils frequently shift size and can signal various things. A dilated pupil may indicate surprise or attraction. Constricted pupils are associated with negative emotions such as anger.

AGGRESSIVE

MORE THAN 50 PERCENT
OF COMMUNICATION
IS BASED ON OUR
BODY LANGUAGE



DO GESTURES
HAVE THE SAME
MEANING AROUND
THE WORLD?

No, many gestures are culturally specific. A simple hand gesture can have different meanings for different societies.